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Strategies of status manipulation in the Wolof greeting

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Joking relationship (kall) and the joking greeting

The greeting forms of the joking relationship are usually initiated by A, the person who initiates the entire greeting, after names have been exchanged (occasionally, if the two parties know each other very well and are on intimate terms, they may skip the naming stage and the regular greeting entirely). The following example illustrates a *kall* greeting:

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A. *Diop!*(B's name)

Diop!

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B. *Ndiaye!* (A's name)

Ndiaye!

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A. *Sant ba neehul!*

That surname is not pleasing!

B. *Neeh na kaay.*

It is so pleasing.

A. *Lekk tyeb!*

(The Diops) eat rice! [luxury food; this means they are greedy]

B. *Ndiaye rek, nyoo ko lekk!*

Only the Ndiayes, it is they who eat it!

This interchange eventually leads into a Statement (of a new topic of post-greeting conversation; see flow chart); or it may be followed by the [illegible] of a normal greeting. That is, a joking greeting usually substitutes for the QP of a normal greeting, and in any case takes precedence over it in both sequencing and interest. We have, then, a third basic type of greeting, contextually defined (this rule reformulates rule (1a)):

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(lb) (i) $G_{A,B}$ →

G_{passing} / A in accountable hurry;
B is of lower rank than
some other person C

G_{normal} / Otherwise

G_{joking} / A, B have certain surnames

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(ii) G_{joking} → #Sal + I + (QP)#

where I → Insult₁ + Insult₂ + ... + Insult_n

Unlike the joking relationship among the Manding as described by Labouret (1934:102), this mutual insult in the Wolof *kall* relationship is not obligatory, although once it is initiated by one party the other must  182 respond in kind. The general effect of the joking greeting, in contrast to the normal greeting, is one of *equality* between the two speakers, an equality which arises from rivalry (or mock rivalry) rather than from concord. This joking rivalry is not a true contest of insults, because one does not try to win, only to match one's partner equally. Even if one speaker were able (or even tried) to out-insult the other he would not achieve any real victory, because the *kall* is a permanent relationship between groups and transcends the relations of individuals in particular encounters. But because of the equality implied in the joking relationship, a joking greeting will be avoided if the *a priori* status difference between the speakers is too great. It is rare to see a joking greeting between a griot and the Imam of the mosque, for instance, although such a greeting might well occur between a griot and a young or low-ranking noble. Similarly, the non-seriousness of the insults prevents them from being used in serious or somber occasions, in which equality, if appropriate to the occasion at all, must be expressed in some other way. For instance, two chiefs each visiting the village of a third chief for a funeral, may, if they wish to express equality, engage in mutual deference, in which each tries to take the lower-status greeting role in a normal greeting, even though their surnames might happen to be in joking relationship.

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